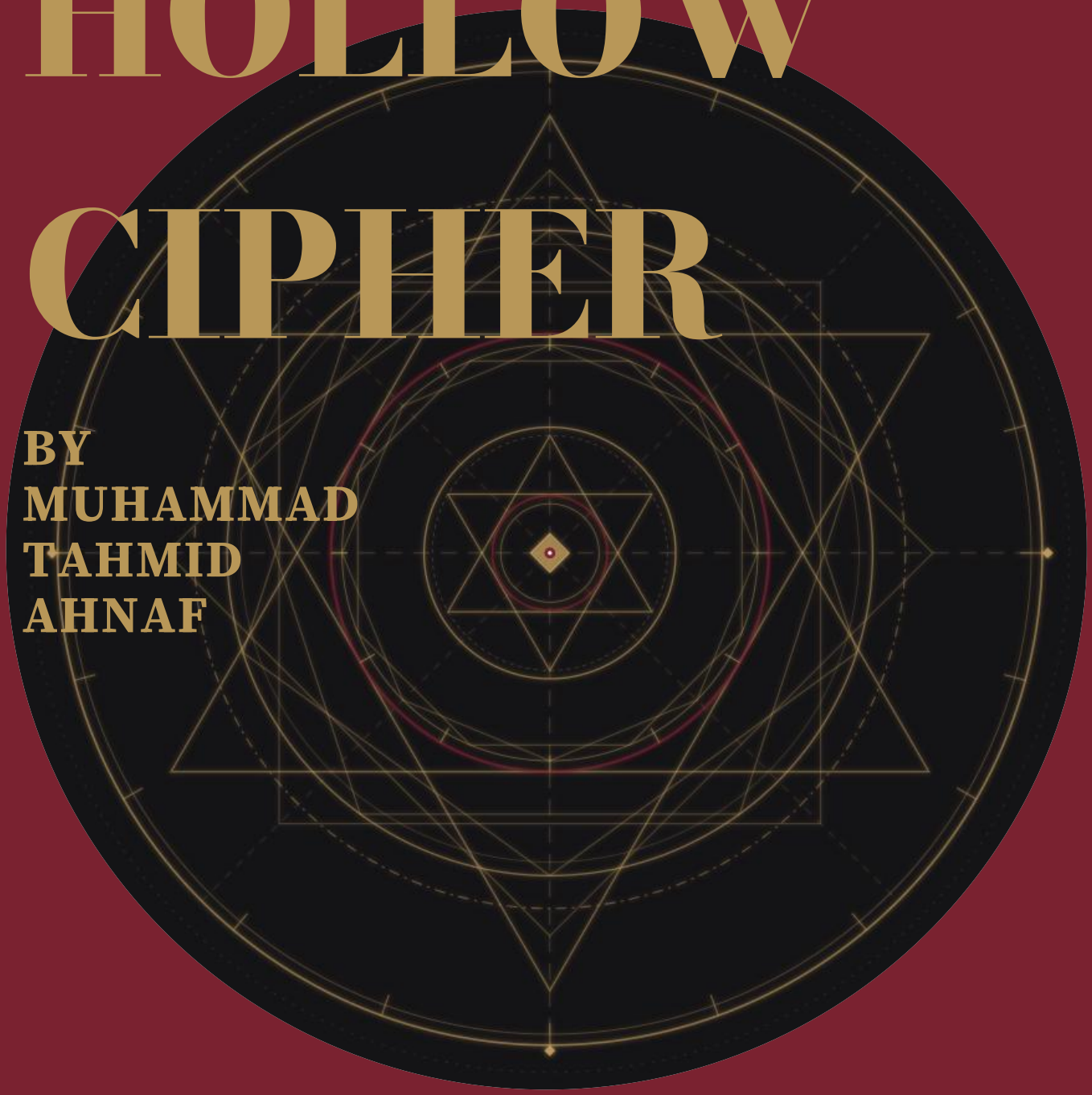
THE HOLLOW CIPHER



BY
MUHAMMAD
TAHMID
AHNAF

LEVEL 1

THE SILENT PATIENT

[Level 1; Case: The Silent Patient]

[Time] 5th October, 1887 | 2:36 AM
[Location] House 17, Block B, Green Road, Gulshan, Dhaka

[Statement]

For six months, journalist Arif Rahman had been following a story that his editor repeatedly told him to abandon.

It began with dead cats.

They appeared first around Palashi. Then Azimpur. Then the narrow alleys behind old warehouses near the Buriganga. Their bodies were never simply mutilated. Their eyes were crushed, sometimes removed entirely, and strange cuts were found across their bodies. There was no obvious pattern to the killings except their cruelty.

Arif believed there was one.

He began collecting reports that had never reached the newspapers. Missing animals. Missing people. Witnesses who suddenly refused to speak. Names that appeared repeatedly in unrelated accounts. Eventually, he gave the investigation a name of his own.

EVIL EYE'S WRATH.

Nobody knew whether that was the name of an organization, a ritual, or something Arif had invented to make sense of the evidence.

His wife, Sultana, knew only that the investigation was consuming him. For weeks, Arif had barely slept. He kept a notebook containing everything he had discovered and refused to let anyone see it. The notebook was kept inside a steel vault in his study.

On the night of 5th October, Arif went to bed at approximately midnight. At 2:36 AM, the electricity to the house was cut. The house went completely dark.

A few minutes later, Sultana woke to the sound of something heavy striking the floor. Then she heard her husband's voice.

Not shouting. Begging.

She ran toward the study. What she saw there would destroy her ability to speak for months.

Three men were inside the room. Arif was fighting one of them. Another was standing beside the steel vault. The third was holding a long knife.

And Sultana knew all three of them. They were her husband's colleagues. Arif saw her. For one brief moment, their eyes met.

Then the knife went into him.

Sultana screamed.

Someone struck her across the head.

The room disappeared.

--- 10:57 AM ---

When she opened her eyes again, she was lying beside her husband's body.

The men were gone. So was the notebook. The scene they left behind told a different story.

The study had been rearranged. The knife had been placed near Sultana's hand.

Arif's desk had been overturned. Several pages had been torn from his investigation. There were signs of a violent struggle between husband and wife. It looked as though Arif had attacked Sultana during an argument, and she had killed him while defending herself. It was almost convincing.

Almost. Because whoever staged the room made one mistake.

They forgot that Sultana was still alive.

She was taken to hospital with severe head trauma. She survived. But when the doctors asked her what happened, she could not speak.

Days passed.

Then weeks.

The investigation began collapsing under its own contradictions. Seven people emerged as possible suspects.

Three had been seen near the house. Two had lied about where they were. One had access to Arif's investigation. And one insisted he had never even known the notebook existed.

Then, on the seventh day after the murder, Sultana asked for a piece of paper. Her hands were trembling.

She wrote:

"His colleagues killed him."

Underneath it, after several minutes of hesitation, she wrote:

"They wanted the notebook."

The police asked her what was inside it. She stared at the question for a long time. Then she wrote:

"EVIL EYE'S WRATH."

A second line followed.

"They tried to erase the investigation."

She suddenly became agitated. The nurse tried to take the paper away. Sultana refused to let go. She wrote one final sentence before collapsing:

"One of them was lying about what happened to Arif."

She never explained which one. Her condition deteriorated that night. Three days later, she was shown photographs of the seven suspects.

She stopped at the photograph of **Durjo Das**.

She stared at it for nearly a minute. Then she looked away.

Later, when shown **Jawer Chakrovarty**, her reaction was completely different.

She began shaking. She pointed at his photograph. And tried to point her finger at him, mumbling:

"HIM."

The case changed direction.

Jawer had already admitted that he was near the house that night. He claimed he had arrived after hearing Arif was in danger. He claimed he never touched him. He claimed the knife was already on the floor. His story was believable. Until the police found out that Jawer owned a knife almost identical to the murder weapon.

Then another problem appeared.

The wound on Arif's body did not quite fit the story. The knife had injured him badly. But it had not killed him.

Something else had.

A substance had entered Arif's bloodstream shortly before his death. A poison.

There was no bottle. No vial. No obvious source. Only a tiny puncture mark on Arif's upper arm that investigators had initially dismissed as insignificant.

Suddenly, the question was no longer simply:

Who stabbed Arif Rahman?

It became:

Who needed everyone to believe that he had been stabbed to death?

And if the knife was never meant to be the murder weapon...

why was Jawer carrying the perfect person to blame?

[POI (Persons of Interest / Prime Suspects)]

1. Jawer Chakrovarty — Senior Reporter, former field partner of Arif
2. Arindom Kumar Biswas — Chief Editor of the newspaper
3. Durjo Das — Investigative Journalist and Arif's colleague
4. Mahir Hossain — Newspaper Photographer
5. Nayeem Ahmed — Newspaper Archivist
6. Shafiq Rahman — Arif's confidential source
7. Kamal Uddin — Night Security Supervisor

[Interrogation]

[Jawer Chakrovarty]:

Jawer initially denies entering the house. When confronted with evidence placing him near Green Road, he changes his story. He admits entering the house but insists he came after receiving a message from Arif. He claims the study was already in chaos when he arrived. He remembers seeing Durjo. He does not remember seeing Arindom.

When asked about the notebook, Jawer says:

"I knew Arif was working on something. I didn't know what."

When asked why Sultana identified him, he becomes silent.

Then says:

"Because she saw me."

He refuses to explain what he means.

[Arindom Kumar Biswas]:

Arindom describes Arif as an increasingly reckless journalist who had become obsessed with an investigation he could not prove. He insists he tried to protect Arif from

publishing "unverified nonsense." He denies knowing about the notebook. He also claims his final conversation with Arif lasted less than two minutes.

Telephone records show it lasted six.

When confronted, Arindom says Arif had forgotten to hang up. He smiles when saying it.

[Durjo Das]:

Durjo admits he knew about the investigation. He claims Arif had accused someone inside the newspaper of destroying evidence. Durjo refuses to say who. He admits being inside the house that night. He says he arrived after hearing Arif scream. His shirt contained a small trace of Arif's blood. He claims he tried to help him. When asked whether he saw Jawer holding the knife, he answers:

"I saw Jawer holding something."

When pressed, he changes it to:

"I think it was the knife."

[Mahir Hossain]:

Mahir photographed several of the dead animals connected to Arif's investigation. The photographs disappeared from the newspaper archive. He claims he does not know where they went. He says Arif had recently become frightened of someone at work. He refuses to name the person.

[Nayeem Ahmed]:

Nayeem managed the newspaper's physical archives. He admits that Arif frequently requested old reports concerning unexplained animal deaths. He denies ever seeing the notebook.

One recovered page contains his handwriting. He claims Arif must have copied something from the archive himself.

[Shafiq Rahman]:

Shafiq was one of Arif's confidential sources. He admits warning Arif to abandon the investigation. He claims the reason was simple:

"Some stories aren't worth dying for."

He denies knowing about Evil Eye's Wrath. When shown the phrase, however, he immediately asks:

"Where did you find that?"

[Kamal Uddin]:

Kamal was responsible for the residential block's night security. He admits that someone asked him about the electrical panel that evening. He initially says he cannot remember who.

Later, he remembers that the person showed him what appeared to be an official identification card. He refuses to describe it.

[Evidences]

1. **The Murder Knife**
   Arif's blood was found on the blade. The handle had been carefully wiped. The knife wound was severe, but later toxicology established that it was not the cause of death.

2. **The Poison**
   An unidentified poison was found in Arif's bloodstream. It appears to have been administered shortly before his death.

3. **The Puncture Mark**
   A tiny puncture was discovered on Arif's upper arm. Initially dismissed as irrelevant, it may correspond to the administration of the poison.

4. **The Missing Notebook**
   Arif's steel vault was opened without visible damage. The notebook containing his investigation was never recovered.

5. **The Burned Page**
   A partially burned sheet was found inside the fireplace. Only the words "EVIL EYE'S WRATH" remained readable.

6. **The Telephone Record**
   Arindom claimed his final conversation with Arif lasted less than two minutes. The telephone record shows six minutes.

7. **The Bloodstained Cuff**
   A small amount of Arif's blood was found on Durjo's sleeve. His explanation that he tried to help Arif cannot be independently confirmed.

8. **The Photograph Archive**
   Several photographs connected to Arif's investigation disappeared from the newspaper archive shortly before his death.

9. **Sultana's Statement**
   Sultana identified Jawer as one of the men present. She never explicitly stated that Jawer killed Arif.

[Past History]

[Arif Rahman]:

A respected investigative journalist. Known for pursuing stories long after others considered them too dangerous or too strange to publish. Had recently accused someone inside his own newspaper of suppressing evidence. Kept sensitive information in handwritten notebooks. Had become increasingly secretive during the final months of his life.

[Arindom Kumar Biswas]:

Chief Editor.

Had worked with Arif for eleven years.

Publicly defended Arif's journalism while privately rejecting several of his recent investigations. Had final authority over publication and access to the newspaper's archives. Was one of the last people known to speak with Arif before his death.

[Durjo Das]:

Investigative journalist.

Worked closely with Arif but had a complicated professional relationship with him. Had accused Arif of taking credit for their joint investigations. Was aware that Arif kept a private notebook.

Was present at the crime scene that night.

[Jawer Chakrovarty]:

Senior reporter and Arif's former field partner. Had accompanied Arif during several visits to Palashi. Had argued with Arif shortly before the murder. Was known to carry a large knife during field assignments.

Admitted being inside the house on the night of the murder.

[Sultana Rahman]:

Arif's wife.

Had no known involvement in his investigation. Was the only surviving eyewitness to the attack.

Her physical and psychological condition makes her testimony fragmented and difficult to interpret.

[Mahir Hossain]:

Newspaper photographer.

Had documented several scenes connected to the investigation. His photographs later disappeared from the newspaper archive.

[Nayeem Ahmed]:

Newspaper archivist.

Had access to restricted historical material. Frequently assisted Arif with his research. Was one of the few people who could locate old reports without leaving an obvious record.

[Shafiq Rahman]:

Arif's confidential source.

Had repeatedly warned Arif to abandon his investigation. Had knowledge of several details about the case that were never published.

[Kamal Uddin]:

Night security supervisor.

Had access to the building's electrical control panel. Claims he saw one of the intruders before the power was cut. His account has changed several times.

[Investigative Direction]

The first appearance of the crime scene suggests a domestic murder.

Sultana appears to be the obvious culprit.

That theory collapses when her injuries, the staged room and the missing notebook are considered. The investigation then points toward the three colleagues seen inside the house. Jawer becomes the strongest apparent suspect after Sultana identifies him. Durjo's inconsistent testimony creates another possibility.

But the discovery of poison changes the nature of the murder entirely. Someone wanted the knife to tell a convincing story.

Someone wanted Jawer to be remembered as the man who killed Arif. And someone knew enough about Arif's investigation to understand exactly what needed to disappear.

[Hidden Resolution]

Jawer was there.

Durjo was there.

Arindom was there.

All three were involved in entering Arif's house and taking the notebook. But only one of them planned for Arif to die.

Arindom had discovered that Arif was close to exposing the deliberate suppression of evidence surrounding the Palashi investigation.

He arranged the break-in under the pretext of retrieving the notebook.

During the confrontation, Arif was poisoned. The knife attack came afterward. Arindom deliberately allowed Jawer's knife to become the apparent murder weapon, knowing Jawer's presence and temper would make him an easy target for suspicion.

The others believed the knife had killed Arif.

Arindom never told them otherwise.

He then helped construct the false domestic-murder scene and remove the notebook. Sultana's testimony was misunderstood. She identified Jawer because Jawer **was there**.

She never said he was the murderer.

Her later attempt to clarify this was interpreted as another confused reaction because of her deteriorating condition. The crucial deduction is therefore not:

"Jawer did it."

It is:

"Why would a murderer need someone else to be holding the knife?"

And that question leads back to the one person who had the motive to erase Arif's investigation, the authority to manipulate its evidence, and the opportunity to turn a group of frightened accomplices into witnesses against one another.

Arindom Kumar Biswas.